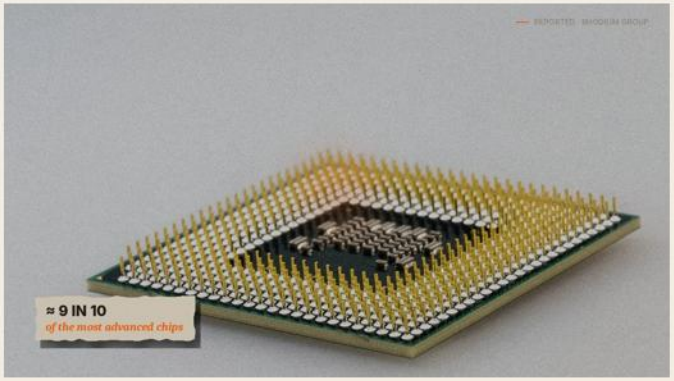
INV-009 · What Happens If China Invades Taiwan?

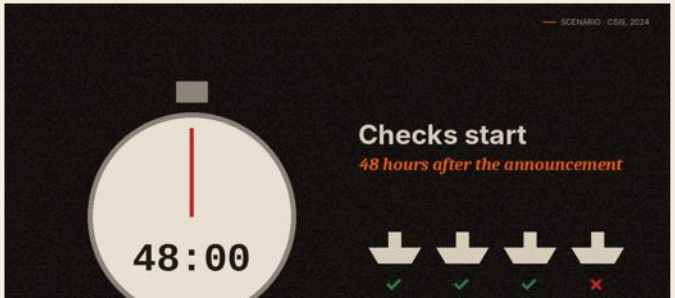
Storyboard v1 · ledger look (same kit as INV-007 and INV-008)

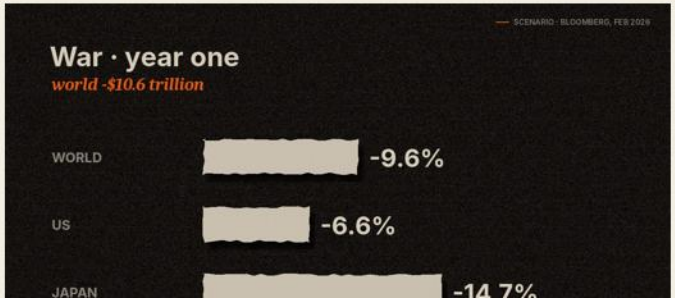
- Script v1: 91 paragraphs · 2416 words · about 19 min of voice, ~20 min cut (can grow to ~30)
- Mix by narration time: graphics 59% · video 26% · photos 16% (target 50 / 30 / 20)
- Every video clip and photo matches the line being spoken. If no match is found, the shot becomes a graphic.
- No 'Illustration' label on screen (YouTube's synthetic-content box is still ticked at upload).
- Photos and clips in this storyboard are first picks from Pixabay; final clips are fetched per line before render.
- Then every paragraph in order, with a grade label under each photo or clip.

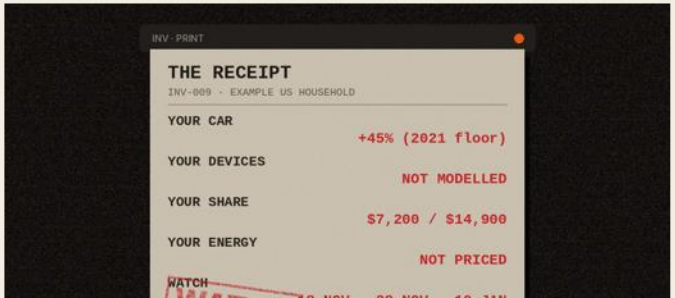


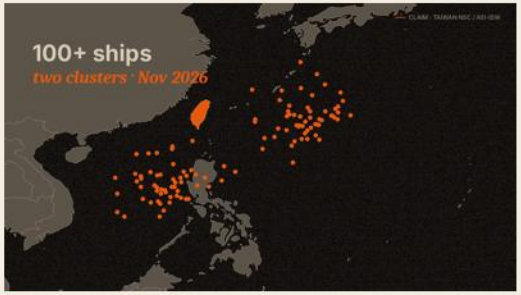












The western Pacific, the first week of November 2026. More than a hundred Chinese navy and coast guard ships, spread across the sea in two great clusters. Beijing hasn't announced a drill.

GRAPHIC **CO-01**

Navy map of the western Pacific: Taiwan outlined, two orange ship clusters bloom east and south, '100+ SHIPS'



So what happens if China invades Taiwan? Or doesn't invade at all, and simply closes the door around it?

VIDEO **CO-02** COLOUR · INTENSE

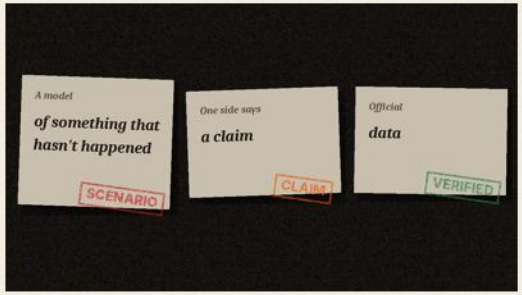
Container ship moving through a strait at dusk, slow push + label 'WHAT HAPPENS IF CHINA INVADES TAIWAN?'



One model from Bloomberg Economics says a war would cut the world economy by nearly ten percent in its first year. For America, that's about fifteen thousand dollars of output for every household.

GRAPHIC **CO-03**

Ledger number: $10.6 TRILLION, then '≈ $15,000 per US household'; 2 s receipt flash



Nobody has fired a shot. These are models of something that hasn't happened, and we'll say that every time. Some numbers are official. Some are claims from one side. We'll tell you which is which.

GRAPHIC **CO-04**

Three typed tag cards stamped SCENARIO · CLAIM · VERIFIED



By the end, you'll see the whole bill, line by line. We'll open the box Taiwan ships to the world, cross the strait, ask why everyone says 2027, watch the rehearsal, count the money, and come back to your table.

GRAPHIC **CO-05**

Roadmap: six stops light in a row



Part one. What's in the box.

GRAPHIC **P1-01**

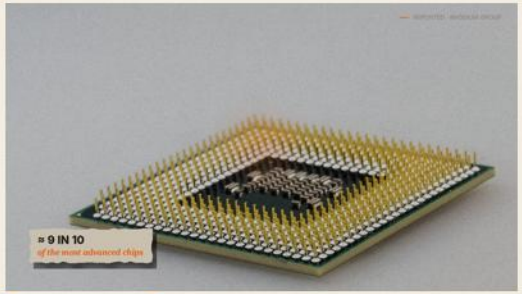
Part card 01 'What Taiwan Makes'



Taiwan is an island of about twenty-three million people, barely the size of Belgium. It sits about a hundred and thirty kilometres off the coast of China.

VIDEO **P1-02** COLOUR · CALM

Taipei skyline with Taipei 101, wide, slow pan + label '23 MILLION PEOPLE · 130 KM FROM CHINA'



And it makes the thing almost everything else depends on. About nine in every ten of the world's most advanced chips are made in Taiwan.

VIDEO **P1-03** COLOUR

Chip wafer under yellow cleanroom light, macro, no faces + label '≈ 9 IN 10 ADVANCED CHIPS'



One company, TSMC, makes nearly seventy percent of all the chips that other firms design and order. At the very top end, it's about ninety percent.

GRAPHIC **P1-04**

New type: double ring fills to 70%, outer ring to 90% (TSMC)



And it isn't only the fancy chips. Taiwan also makes somewhere between a third and a half of the older, cheaper chips that run fridges, power tools and car windows.

PHOTO **P1-04b** COLOUR · CALM

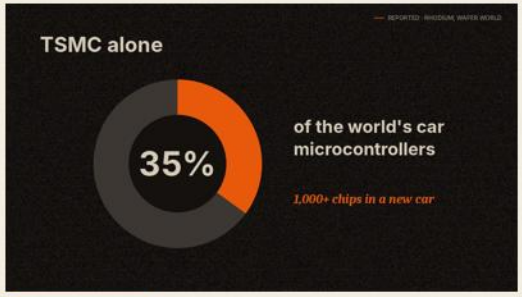
Kitchen appliances / fridge and power tools, still with slow push + label 'OLDER CHIPS: 1/3 TO 1/2'



If you have an iPhone, its brain was almost certainly made there. So are the AI chips from Nvidia that run the world's data centres. In 2026, Nvidia passed Apple as TSMC's biggest customer.

VIDEO **P1-05** COLOUR

Phone circuit board macro, slow slide + label 'NVIDIA ≈22% · APPLE ≈18% OF TSMC'



It's not only phones. A new car holds a thousand chips or more. TSMC alone is reported to make about a third of the world's car microcontrollers.

GRAPHIC **P1-06**

Donut: TSMC ≈35% of the world's car microcontrollers; '1,000+ chips in a new car' (no matching car-line clip found without faces)



In 2025, Taiwan exported a record six hundred and forty billion dollars of goods. Almost a third went to the United States.

VIDEO **P1-07** COLOUR · INTENSE

Container port at night, cranes loading ships + label '$640.7BN EXPORTS · 30.9% TO THE US'



Now, we already know what happens when those chips run short. Because it happened in 2021, and nothing was even broken.

GRAPHIC **P1-08**

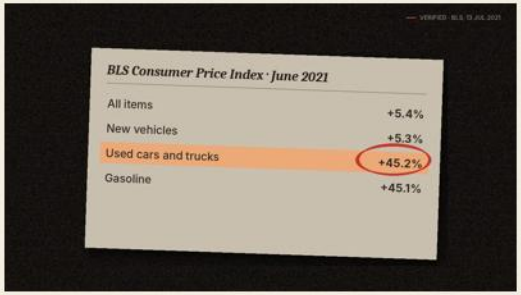
New type: year stamp card '2021 · THE DRESS REHEARSAL'



Demand for laptops and screens jumped, a few factories stumbled, and car makers couldn't get enough chips. About seven point seven million cars were never built that year.

VIDEO **P1-09** SHADOW

Rows of parked new cars / empty factory lot, still and quiet + label '7.7 MILLION CARS NOT BUILT'



In America, used car prices rose forty-five percent in twelve months. The government said it was the biggest jump it had ever recorded. Buyers paid about ninety billion dollars more worldwide.

GRAPHIC **P1-10**

Document: BLS CPI release, used-cars row highlighted, red pen circle on 45.2%



One estimate puts the cost of that shortage to America at about one percent of its whole economy. Nearly two hundred and forty billion dollars, from a hiccup.

GRAPHIC **P1-10b**

Mini-chart tiles: SHORTAGE COST ≈ $240BN · ≈ 1% OF US GDP



On a twenty-five-thousand-dollar used car, that's about eleven thousand dollars more, in a year. And every chip plant in Taiwan was still running.

GRAPHIC **P1-11**

Price tags: $25,000 → $36,300 on a used car tag; 'TAIWAN: OPEN'



So what happens when it's not the factories that stop, but the sea around them?

GRAPHIC **P1-12**

Map push in on the strait



If you want to see every line of a bill like this before it arrives, subscribe. Next, we'll follow it to the table, the way we followed Hormuz to your fuel and your heating.

GRAPHIC **BR-01**

Envelope: next invoice tile (INV-006 Winter Bill) + SUBSCRIBE



Part two. The strait.

GRAPHIC **P2-01**

Part card 02 'The Strait'



The Taiwan Strait is one of the busiest stretches of water on Earth. In 2022, about two point four five trillion dollars of goods passed through it. More than a fifth of all the trade that moves by sea.

GRAPHIC **P2-02**

Navy map: shipping lanes thread through the Taiwan Strait, '$2.45 TRILLION · 1/5 OF SEA TRADE'



In the first seven months of that year, nearly half of the world's container ships went through it at some point.

VIDEO **P2-03** COLOUR

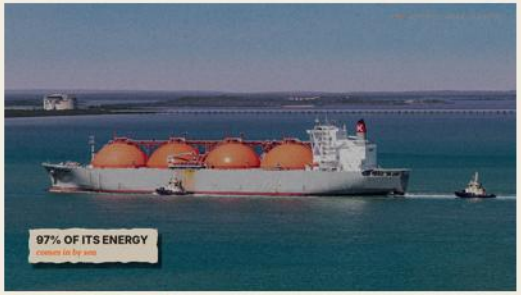
Container ship from above, stacked boxes, slow drift + label '≈ HALF OF ALL CONTAINER SHIPS'



Now look at where Taiwan's ports are. Kaohsiung, Taichung, Taipei, Keelung. The big ones all face China. Kaohsiung alone handles more than half of Taiwan's sea trade.

GRAPHIC **P2-04**

Map: five port pins on Taiwan's west coast; Kaohsiung pulses '57%'



That matters, because Taiwan has to bring almost everything in by sea. It imports ninety-seven percent of its energy.

VIDEO **P2-05** COLOUR · CALM

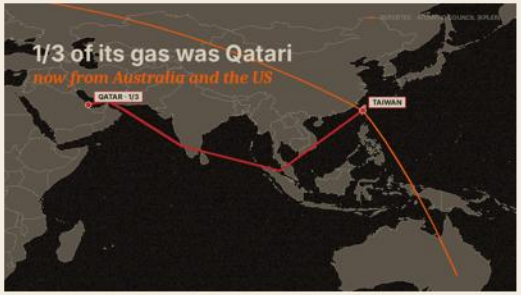
LNG tanker at a terminal, gas domes + label '97% OF ENERGY IMPORTED'



About half of its electricity comes from gas, shipped in as LNG. And in winter, it keeps about eleven days of it. In summer, about seven.

PHOTO **P2-06** COLOUR · CALM

Round gas storage tanks at a terminal, still with slow push + new type countdown dial inset '11 DAYS'



Here's where our Hormuz story comes back. About a third of Taiwan's gas came from Qatar. Since March, it has had to scramble for cargoes from Australia and America instead.

GRAPHIC **P2-07**

Map: Qatar → Taiwan line through Hormuz cuts; new lines from Australia and the US



It's not only gas. Before the Iran war, about seventy percent of Taiwan's crude oil came from the Middle East. Its oil reserve is deeper, about five months. Its gas reserve is the thin one.

PHOTO **P2-07b** COLOUR · CALM

Oil refinery tanks at dusk, still + label 'OIL ≈ 5 MONTHS · GAS ≈ 11 DAYS'



So Taiwan has already lived one year with its gas lifeline squeezed from far away. The question is what happens if someone squeezes it from close by.

VIDEO **P2-08** SHADOW

Tanker at sea at night, small and alone + label 'SQUEEZED FROM FAR AWAY'



And why does everyone in Washington keep saying the same year?

PHOTO **P2-09** COLOUR

US Capitol dome, still, slow push + label 'WHY 2027?'



Part three. Why everyone says 2027.

GRAPHIC **P3-01**

Part card 03 'Why Everyone Says 2027'



In 2021, the top American admiral in the Pacific, Philip Davidson, told the Senate that China was on course to be able to seize Taiwan by 2027. The six years before that date became known as the Davidson window.

VIDEO **P3-02** COLOUR · CALM

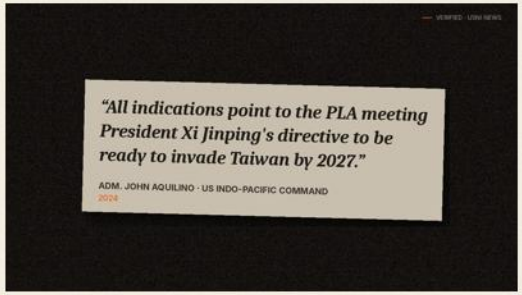
US Capitol / Senate exterior, slow move + label 'THE DAVIDSON WINDOW · 2021-2027'



In 2023, the head of the CIA said American intelligence showed Xi Jinping had told his military to be ready by 2027. Ready by. Not that he would.

GRAPHIC **P3-03**

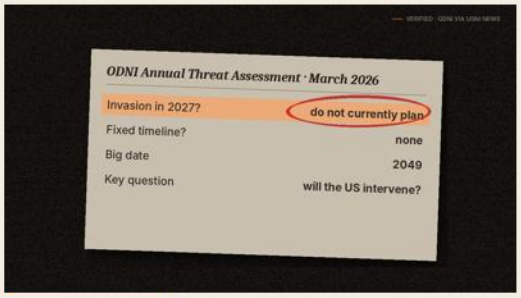
Typed card 'READY BY 2027', red pen underline on READY BY; stamp REPORTED



In 2024, the next Pacific commander said it again. All indications, he said, point to the military meeting Xi's directive to be ready to invade by 2027.

GRAPHIC **P3-04**

Quote card: 'All indications point to...' Adm. Aquilino, 2024



Then, in March 2026, US intelligence published its yearly threat report. Its words: Chinese leaders do not currently plan to invade Taiwan in 2027. Beijing has no fixed timeline. Its big date is 2049.

GRAPHIC **P3-05**

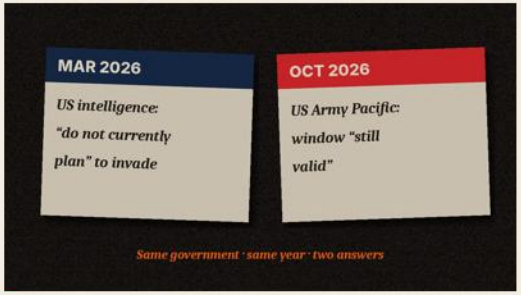
Document: ODNI 2026 threat report, 'do not currently plan' highlighted and circled



2049 is the hundredth birthday of the People's Republic. That's the deadline Beijing has set for what it calls national rejuvenation, and for a world-class military.

GRAPHIC **P3-05b**

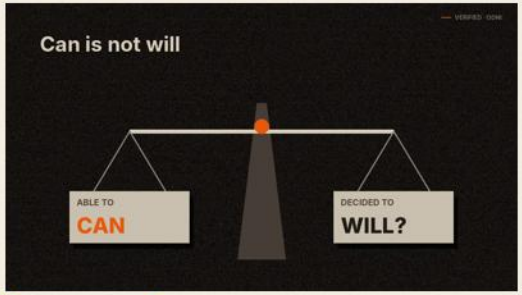
Timeline: 2021 · 2027 · 2049 (PRC at 100)



And seven months later, in October 2026, the US Army's Pacific commander said the 2027 window is still valid. We need to be ready by this date, he said.

GRAPHIC **P3-06**

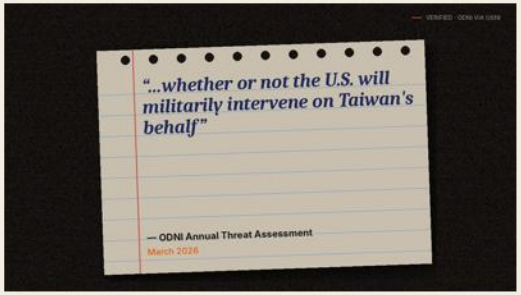
Two halves: MAR 2026 'DO NOT CURRENTLY PLAN' vs OCT 2026 'STILL VALID'



So which is it? Both, in a way. Being able to do something isn't the same as deciding to. The same report says China is building the readiness to invade, and that it would rather win without a fight.

GRAPHIC **P3-07**

Scale: CAN vs WILL, not balanced



And one thing the report says Beijing will weigh is simple. Whether the United States would fight.

GRAPHIC **P3-08**

Notebook page: '...whether or not the U.S. will militarily intervene' (ODNI 2026)



Here's the money link. Every year this stays a question, insurers, chip buyers and car makers pay a little more to plan around it. Nobody has put one number on that yet, so we won't.

GRAPHIC **P3-09**

Folder + index cards: INSURE · STOCKPILE · SECOND FACTORY · NO NUMBER YET



But we can watch what the ships are doing. And in the last year, they've been practising something.

GRAPHIC **P3-10**

Map pulls back to the western Pacific; ship dots



Part four. The rehearsal.

GRAPHIC **P4-01**

Part card 04 'The Rehearsal'



On the twenty-ninth of December 2025, China launched drills it called Justice Mission 2025. On the first day, a hundred and thirty military aircraft flew around Taiwan. Ninety crossed the line down the middle of the strait.

GRAPHIC **P4-02**

Map: median line; 130 aircraft dots, 90 across it



There were rocket firings and practice landings. Two days later, it was over.

GRAPHIC **P4-03**

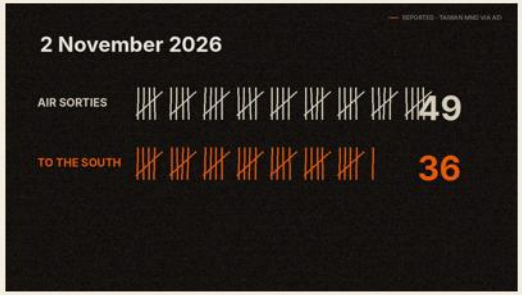
Calendar: 29 · 30 · 31 DEC 2025, DONE stamp



Then, at the start of November 2026, came something bigger. Taiwan says more than a hundred Chinese ships were out at once, from the South China Sea into the Pacific. Two aircraft carriers had left port.

GRAPHIC **P4-04**

Map: Liaoning and Fujian icons move out past the Philippines; '100+ SHIPS · 2 CARRIERS'



On a single day, the second of November, Taiwan counted forty-nine Chinese air sorties near the island. Thirty-six of them were to the south, around the route the carriers took.

GRAPHIC **P4-04b**

Tally: 49 sorties, 36 to the south (2 Nov 2026)



American analysts think it may have been an unannounced exercise in cutting Taiwan off. Taiwan's defence minister calls it area denial. That means keeping outside help away. China says its carrier training is routine.

GRAPHIC **P4-05**

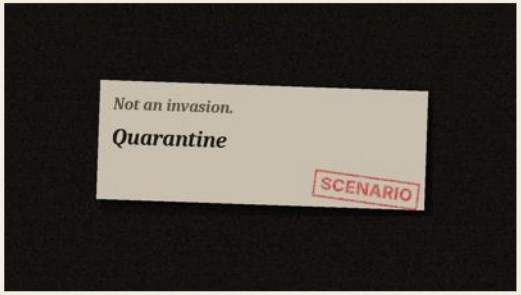
Bubbles: AEI/ISW 'assessment' · Taiwan 'area denial' · China 'routine'



It isn't only ships. Taiwan's security bureau says the island faced about two point six million cyberattacks a day in 2025. More than double two years before.

PHOTO **P4-05b** COLOUR

Server room aisle with blue lights, still + label '2.63M CYBERATTACKS A DAY'



So here's the scenario most experts worry about first. Not an invasion. Something quieter, called a quarantine.

GRAPHIC **P4-06**

Typed card QUARANTINE, stamp SCENARIO



In a blockade, the military surrounds the island, and there could be missiles and mines. In a quarantine, it's the coast guard. Ships are stopped and inspected, like a customs check that never ends. On paper, it isn't war.

VIDEO **P4-07** COLOUR · INTENSE

Coast guard patrol ship at sea, distant, no flags in focus + label 'QUARANTINE = A CUSTOMS CHECK THAT NEVER ENDS'



China's coast guard has more than a hundred and fifty ocean-going ships. Taiwan's has about ten.

GRAPHIC **P4-08**

New type: icon grid 150 cutters vs 10



In one CSIS model, checks start about forty-eight hours after the announcement. And it works if three in four shipping firms simply go along with it, to avoid the risk.

GRAPHIC **P4-09**

New type: stopwatch 48:00 + 3 of 4 ships comply



Remember the gas. Eleven days in winter. Start the clock forty-eight hours after an announcement, and Taiwan has about nine days of gas before the lights become a choice.

VIDEO **P4-10** SHADOW

City skyline at night, lights (shadow grade) + label '≈ 9 DAYS OF GAS LEFT'



And would America send ships to break a coast guard check? In a CSIS survey, only thirteen percent of American experts were completely confident it would.

GRAPHIC **P4-11**

Columns: 13% US experts · 9% Taiwan experts 'completely confident'



Let's stop and print what we have so far. A chip shortage with every plant open: used cars up forty-five percent. A quiet quarantine: a gas clock of about nine days, on an island that makes nine in ten of the best chips.

GRAPHIC **P4-12**

Receipt: HALF-RECEIPT, three lines



So what would the full thing cost the rest of us?

PHOTO **P4-13** **SHADOW**

Container terminal stacks at dusk, still + label 'WHAT WOULD IT COST?'



Part five. The money.

GRAPHIC **P5-01**

Part card 05 'The Money'



In February 2026, Bloomberg Economics updated its model of what a Taiwan crisis would cost in the first year. It ran two versions. A blockade, and a war.

GRAPHIC **P5-02**

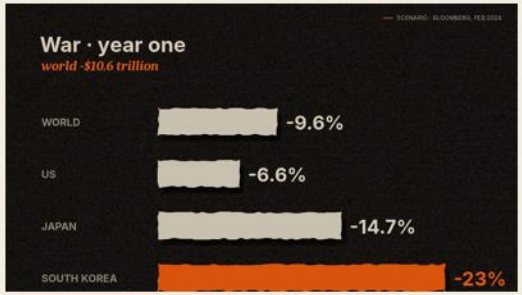
Clipboards: BLOCKADE vs WAR (Bloomberg Economics, Feb 2026)



A blockade alone: the world economy shrinks by about five percent. America by about three. China by nearly nine.

GRAPHIC **P5-03**

Mini-chart tiles: WORLD -5.3% · US -3.2% · CHINA -8.9% · TAIWAN -12.5%



A war: the world shrinks by nearly ten percent. That's about ten point six trillion dollars. America by six and a half percent. Japan by almost fifteen. South Korea by twenty-three.

GRAPHIC **P5-04**

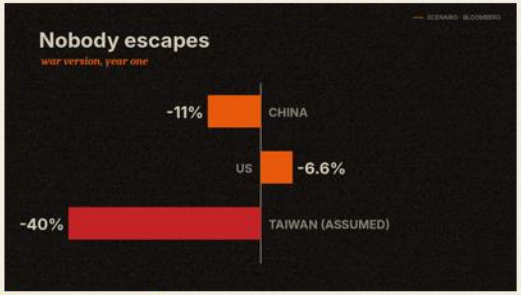
Bars: WORLD -9.6% · US -6.6% · CHINA -11% · JAPAN -14.7% · KOREA -23%



For comparison, in 2020, the year of COVID, America's economy shrank by two point two percent. Both Taiwan versions are worse.

VIDEO **P5-05** SHADOW

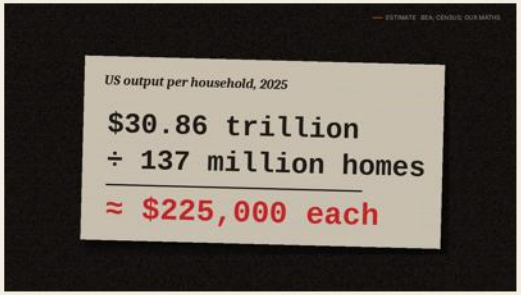
Empty city street in 2020 lockdown style, no people (shadow) + label 'COVID 2020: -2.2%'



And China doesn't escape. In the war version, its economy shrinks by eleven percent. Taiwan's by an assumed forty. Everyone who starts this pays for it.

GRAPHIC **P5-05b**

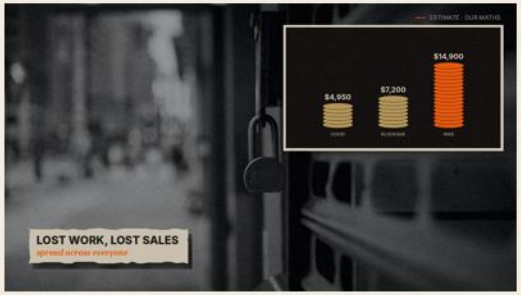
New type: mirror bars CHINA -11% · US -6.6% · TAIWAN -40% (assumed)



Let's turn that into a household. America produced about thirty point nine trillion dollars in 2025. There are about a hundred and thirty-seven million households. That's about two hundred and twenty-five thousand dollars of output each.

GRAPHIC **P5-06**

New type: long division on ruled paper $30.86T ÷ 137M ≈ $225K



A blockade takes about seven thousand dollars of that. A war, about fifteen thousand. COVID took about five. It's not money out of your pay packet line by line. It's lost work, lost sales, and lost hours, spread across everyone.

PHOTO **P5-07** SHADOW

Closed shop with shutter down, still (shadow) + new type coin stacks inset $4,950 · $7,200 · $14,900



Rhodium Group, another research firm, looked only at a blockade. It said well over two trillion dollars of activity would be at risk, and called that a floor, not a ceiling.

GRAPHIC **P5-08**

Ticket: '$2 TRILLION+' stamped FLOOR, NOT CEILING



About one point six trillion of that is yearly revenue at firms that need chips. Phones, laptops, cars, medical machines, the servers behind AI.

VIDEO **P5-09** COLOUR

Electronics production line, circuit boards on a conveyor, no faces + label '$1.6 TRILLION CHIP-DEPENDENT SALES'



In 2025, Taiwan sold about two hundred billion dollars of goods to America alone. Much of it was the servers and parts behind AI. A sealed strait stops that in a week.

VIDEO **P5-09b** COLOUR · INTENSE

Gantry crane lifting a container onto a ship + label '≈ $198BN TAIWAN → US · 2025'



Why can't the chips just be made somewhere else? They're trying. TSMC has promised up to a hundred and sixty-five billion dollars for factories in Arizona. But one top-end plant costs more than twenty billion and takes years to build.

VIDEO **P5-10** COLOUR · CALM

Big construction site with cranes in a desert, no logos + label '$165BN ARIZONA · $20BN+ PER PLANT'



In 2021, we saw what a chip shortage did to car prices with every plant open. A blockade is that, on the scale of the whole factory floor.

GRAPHIC **P5-11**

Return of the 2021 year card (same explanation as P1-08): '2021 × the whole island' (car-lot photos all had brand badges in focus)



But these are the costs of a crisis. What's the cost of the deals that might stop one?

PHOTO **P5-12** SHADOW

Empty conference table with flags, still + label 'WHAT DO THE DEALS COST?'



Part six. The deal.

GRAPHIC **P6-01**

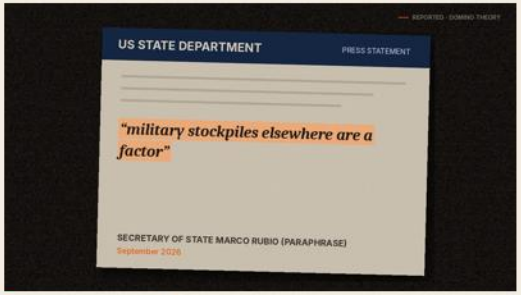
Part card 06 'The Deal'



In May 2026, Taiwan's lawmakers approved money for a fourteen-billion-dollar package of American weapons. Then the President met Xi Jinping in Beijing. Afterwards, he called the package a very good negotiating chip. It's been on hold since.

GRAPHIC **P6-02**

Notice: $14BN US ARMS PACKAGE, stamp ON HOLD (no matching Legislative Yuan photo found)



In September, the Secretary of State said American weapons stocks elsewhere were part of the decision. A weapon sent to one war is a weapon another can't have.

GRAPHIC **P6-02b**

Letter: press statement card 'stockpiles elsewhere' (Rubio, Sep 2026)



In September, a Hong Kong paper reported that Washington might hold big Taiwan arms sales until after the next summit, maybe to the end of the year.

PHOTO **P6-03** COLOUR · CALM

Stack of newspapers, still + label 'HELD UNTIL AFTER APEC?'



That summit is APEC, in Shenzhen, on the eighteenth and nineteenth of November. Ten days later, Taiwan holds local elections. In December, the leaders meet again at the G20 in Florida.

VIDEO **P6-04** COLOUR · INTENSE

Shenzhen skyline, slow pan + label '18-19 NOV APEC · 28 NOV TAIWAN VOTES · DEC G20'



And the trade truce between America and China only runs to the tenth of January 2027. That's the date your shop prices and tariffs hang on, and Taiwan is on the same table.

VIDEO **P6-05** COLOUR

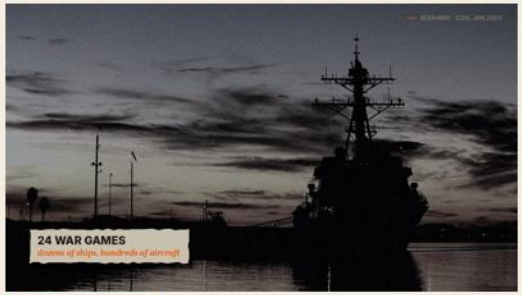
Supermarket aisle, shelf price labels, no faces + label 'TRADE TRUCE ENDS 10 JAN 2027'



Here's the link back to Hormuz. Iran says the strait will reopen to Chinese ships, with special terms on fees. China is buying calm in one sea while it rehearses in another.

VIDEO **P6-06** COLOUR

Oil tanker under way in the Gulf + label 'HORMUZ: OPEN TO CHINESE SHIPS (IRAN CLAIM)'



What if the deals fail and it does come to war? In twenty-four war games in 2023, CSIS found that America, Taiwan and Japan usually stopped an invasion. But they lost dozens of ships, hundreds of aircraft, and tens of thousands of service members. Taiwan's economy was devastated.

VIDEO **P6-07** SHADOW

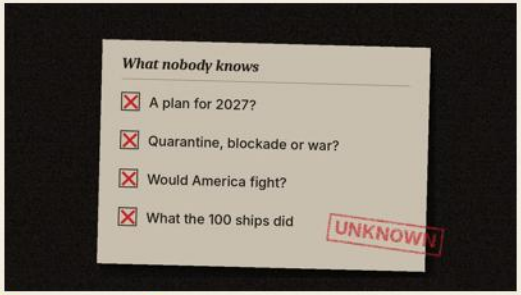
Empty naval pier at dusk, still water, no combat (shadow) + label '24 WAR GAMES'



That's the side of the bill no model prices. Twenty-three million people on the island. And the families of everyone sent to defend it.

PHOTO **P6-08** SHADOW

Taipei at night from a distance, lights on, no faces (shadow) + label '23 MILLION PEOPLE'



And we should be honest about what nobody knows. Whether Beijing plans anything for 2027. Whether it would be a quarantine, a blockade or a war. Whether America would fight. And what those hundred ships were really doing.

GRAPHIC **P6-08b**

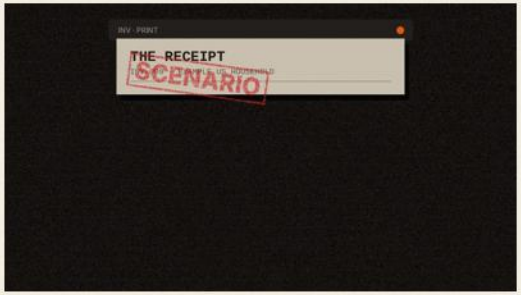
Pinboard: four index cards stamped UNKNOWN



So, line by line, what does it come to at your table?

PHOTO **P6-09** COLOUR

A kitchen table with bills and a calculator, still + label 'AT YOUR TABLE'



The Receipt. For an example American family. These are scenarios, not forecasts. Nobody knows if any of this happens.

GRAPHIC **RC-01**

Receipt header: THE RECEIPT · SCENARIOS, NOT FORECASTS



Line one. Your car. The 2021 shortage added about forty-five percent to used cars, with Taiwan open. Treat that as the floor.

PHOTO **RC-02** COLOUR

Used car with a price sign in the windscreen, still + receipt line 1 inset



Line two. Your phone, laptop and anything with a screen. Nine in ten of the best chips come from one island. Price: not modelled. Supply: at risk.

PHOTO **RC-03** COLOUR · CALM

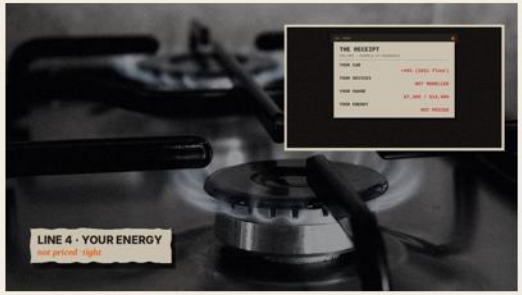
Laptop and phone on a desk, still + receipt line 2 inset 'NOT MODELLED'



Line three. Your share of the economy. A blockade: about seven thousand dollars a household. A war: about fifteen thousand. In year one.

GRAPHIC **RC-04**

Receipt: line 3 YOUR SHARE ≈ $7,200 / ≈ $14,900



Line four. Your energy. Japan, Korea and Taiwan would all be bidding for gas, in a year when Hormuz is already tight. Not priced yet.

PHOTO **RC-05** SHADOW

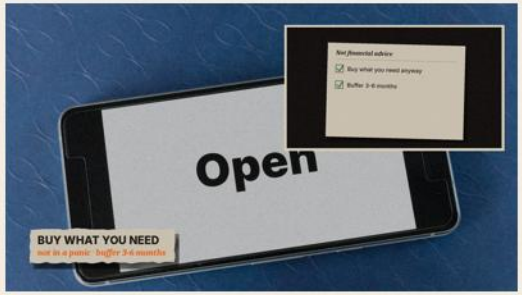
Gas hob flame in a dark kitchen, still + receipt line 4 inset



Line five. The dates to watch. The eighteenth of November. The twenty-eighth of November. The tenth of January.

GRAPHIC **RC-06**

Receipt: line 5 WATCH 18 NOV · 28 NOV · 10 JAN



What can you do? This is not financial advice. But some things make sense in any crisis. If you need a new phone, laptop or car anyway, don't wait for the next shock to buy it. Keep three to six months of essential bills in a buffer.

PHOTO **RC-07** COLOUR · CALM

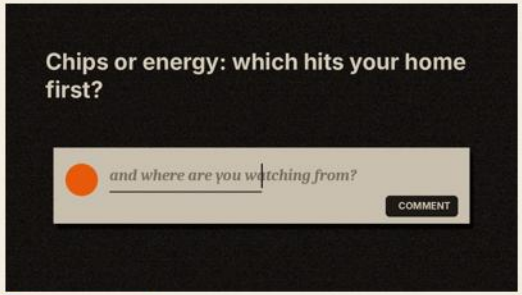
Phone shop display shelf, still + index cards BUY WHAT YOU NEED · BUFFER 3-6 MONTHS



Test your budget with prices twenty percent higher. And don't trade on headlines. A summit photo can move markets in a day, and a drill can move them back.

GRAPHIC **RC-08**

Steps: +20% STRESS TEST · DON'T TRADE HEADLINES



Tell us in the comments. Which would hit your home first, the chips or the energy? And where are you watching from?

GRAPHIC **RC-09**

Comment card: CHIPS OR ENERGY: WHICH HITS YOU FIRST?



Out in the Pacific, the ships will go home, or they won't. The bill is already being written. Every crisis sends a bill. History keeps the receipts.

VIDEO **RC-10** COLOUR · CALM

Open ocean at dusk, empty horizon, slow drift; fade to the plain end card